one film at a time, I get bored," he adds. In an ideal world, he would work on one film at a time, but then he can't refuse his long list of frequent collaborators—the likes of Anurag Basu, Imtiaz Ali, Ayan Mukerji and Kabir Khan. The composer has built quite a reputation too. Like A.R. Rahman, he is a night crawler and is also known to tweak the album till the nth hour, making audio labels and directors nervous. The result is that, in some instances, the album has come after the film's release.

Pritam is aware of his reputation for being finicky. "Guys who are close to me and understand my process never complain about it. They know I am working on it," he says. "I am the last man standing with the director all the time." Never satisfied with the end product, Pritam lets go only when he enjoys the song in the comfort of his car. He rarely listens to it again after it's done.

Pritam has two projects on his bucket list: an independent album and the soundtrack of a Bengali film

Great success has come at a great price, though. The manic pace of work has meant that Pritam has had to take two sabbaticals in the past decade. "Any movie given to me, I take it as a responsibility and when the songs don't do enough to promote the film well, I take it very personally," he says. His doctors as well as his wife admonish him for his unhealthy work rate and lifestyle, which he admits he needs to change. Every now and then, a whisper campaign of his retirement, some may say initiated by Pritam himself, begins, sending most of the film industry in panic mode. He doesn't want to retire from music, he notes, but from "commercial films", which leave him with little time to work on his two bucket list projects: working on an independent album and the soundtrack of a Bengali film.

In two decades of creating memorable soundtracks, Pritam has already made a lasting impact. It's evident in the success of lyricist Amitabh Bhattacharya, singers Arijit Singh, Amit Mishra and Antara Mitra, composers Nakash Aziz and Sachin Jigar, all of whom have assisted him. Referred to as the hit machine, he dwells on how a song's success is not entirely under his control, with "picturisation and marketing" playing a role too. He notices the changing trends in film music, with filmmakers shying away from albums with a longer track list and longer duration and embracing multiple composers for a film. "One script has one colour," he says. "I am a purist that way. I'd like to do the whole film. I don't want to do one-off songs." He would also like more credit for himself and his peers. "At times, posters don't carry our name. I don't push it so much," he says, noting that film industries in the South are better in this regard. "We need to change it here."

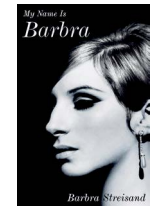
Apart from *Merry Christmas,* Pritam enters 2024 with at least one other film album—his friend Basu's *Metro...In Dino*. A low delivery rate by his own lofty standards. Says Pritam, "There's a lot of work for everybody." And in his case, there's always more than enough. ■

Suhani Singh

MUSICAL MEMOIRS

SING ME A STORY

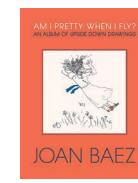
Page-turners from three influential divas



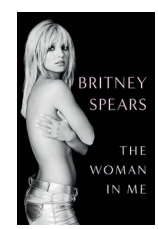
MY NAME IS BARBRA
By Barbra Streisand
VIKING
$**47; 992** pages

A born songstress, Streisand has been lobbing musical bottles into the sea for a while now: 57 albums, a Broadway career, 12 movies with her in the starring role and, now, a 1,000-page memoir. Streisand takes us for a long drive; we meet her mother who never gave her a compliment; Marlon Brando, who greets her by kissing her back; John F. Kennedy, to whom she says, "You're a doll"; and Pierre Trudeau, "a combination of Albert Einstein and Napoleon (only taller)". We find out why she didn't perform live for 27 years.

"Long before I picked up the ukulele, I picked up the pencil and found refuge in drawing," writes 82-year-old Baez, introducing her new book of sketches. The solidity of themes contrasts with the fluidity of process: she draws upside down, with her "non-dominant hand", which is also how she sometimes writes. Baez reckons "there is a neurological explanation" for her method, but "there's a lot to be said for letting go and doing something simply because it feels right".



AM I PRETTY WHEN I FLY? An Album of Upside Down Drawings
By Joan Baez
DAVID R. GODINE PUBLISHER INC
₹**3,472; 128** pages



THE WOMAN IN ME
By Britney Spears
SIMON & SCHUSTER
₹**999** (hardback); **288** pages

This, finally, is Britney Spears telling her own story. The memoir details the harsh conservatorship she was put under; she's forced to be on lithium and her reproductive rights taken away. Despite putting out four albums and doing multiple shows in the period, she's locked up and put under surveillance: "I had been so infantilized...I became a child-robot". The book takes in her relationship with Justin Timberlake, which ends in an aborted pregnancy, and acknowledges the role of the #FreeBritney movement.

by Palash Krishna Mehrotra